

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	Medium

Question

The following text is from Joseph Conrad’s 1907 novel *The Secret Agent: A Simple Tale*. Mr. Verloc is navigating the London streets on his way to a meeting.

Before reaching Knightsbridge, Mr. Verloc took a turn to the left out of the busy main thoroughfare, uproarious with the traffic of swaying omnibuses and trotting vans, in the almost silent, swift flow of hansoms [horse-drawn carriages]. Under his hat, worn with a slight backward tilt, his hair had been carefully brushed into respectful sleekness; for his business was with an Embassy. And Mr. Verloc, steady like a rock—a soft kind of rock—marched now along a street which could with every propriety be described as private.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined phrase in the text as a whole?

Answer

- A. It qualifies an earlier description of Mr. Verloc.
- B. It emphasizes an internal struggle Mr. Verloc experiences.
- C. It contrasts Mr. Verloc with his surroundings.
- D. It reveals a private opinion Mr. Verloc holds.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The underline phrase qualifies (meaning adds limits or conditions to) the description of Mr. Verloc as “steady like a rock,” adding that he is a “soft” rock.

Choice B is incorrect. In fact, the passage never mentions Mr. Verloc experiencing any internal struggles. Choice C is incorrect. The underlined phrase doesn’t contrast Mr. Verloc with his surroundings, but is instead modifying the description of him as a rock. Choice D is incorrect. The underlined phrase doesn’t reveal a private opinion Mr. Verloc holds: instead, it further describes his character for the reader.